

Turning up the volume with Audible

We have a sit down with **Don Katz**, the CEO of Audible and **Shailesh Sawlani**, Indian GM of Audible to learn more about their foray into the Indian market.

Mithun Mohandas | mithun@digit.in

Q What does the Audible India launch mean for the end users?

Don Katz: It means that they have the chance to access 200,000 English language titles plus 400 titles that have been made especially for this launch of original programming and that they can get it for ₹199. It means there are tens of thousands of customers who are already India-based customers who use the British service can stop paying as much money. And it also means that this is the beginning of new launches from Audible that will happen all the time.

It particularly means that we will not only come in as we always do and embrace the listener, but also the creative professional. And that goes across acting of all stripes, writing of all stripes and then the intermediaries like producers and directors, sound engineers and production companies and all the different people who are in this incredibly rich, almost cultural explosion, that's happening in India as most profoundly has happened anywhere in the world. I mean, this is an amazing time for all the media platforms to be used in India and then from there we can move into local languages. So I think any Indian who like to drive or have time that they're not looking at screens or books will find time, just to give us about an hour or two.



Don Katz, CEO, Audible

Q Will customers get the option to merge marketplaces and carry their books over?

Don: Anything in your library, you own that forever. So you can always sign back in and get to those pieces but I think for now you'll make a new library for the Indian service and then you'll be paying obviously a lot less than you're paying in the UK.

Q Will titles and books which are banned in India be available on the Audible platform?

Shailesh: Generally everything that you bought from those marketplaces will be confined to the

libraries of those marketplaces, so like Don mentioned you can basically sign out of the UK store and sign into the Indian marketplace and get access to the Indian marketplace at that price point and access the content that's on that particular marketplace. The Indian marketplace would be customized to be in compliance with publishing and licensing agreements in place.

Q So if I were to switch my marketplace to UK I can access that data even though I'm physically in India but if I switch my marketplace to India then I won't be able to. Did I get that right?

Shailesh: First, you need to have an

American credit card or a UK credit card to be able to access those services. You'd only expect an American or UK based customer to have that.

Q So there's no geo-blocking system than controls access to a marketplace based on your IP address?

Shailesh: So it's actually the other way around, where someone that needs to access the Indian service really needs to have an Indian card and needs to go to the multi factor authentication process such that those rights management are actually maintained.

Q I was talking to a few existing Audible subscribers – usually they don't prefer to consume fictional content in audio form. For most of them, it was due to the difference between the character in their story, when the narrator's voice doesn't match up to what you had imagined, there's this cognitive dissonance. Does your market research reflect something similar?

Don: Only a subset of people who were deeply textually habituated or also gifted – I'm one of those readers – will take a little longer to understand

the brilliance of a better interpreter than others while interpreting a novel. They're both, based on text but the interpretive refraction between the director and the actor is the reason that it makes sense to you as a movie or a play. So there's a certain kind of early adopter who just wants to read more and they tend to, at first,

maybe not hear the way that book was written. You learn to allow that other person to interpret for you. It is a very discernible behaviour that particularly we saw early on because so many of the people were already readers. **Q**



Shailesh Sawlani, India GM, Audible